

BERNERA NEWS

A Community Newsletter 
in association with

IN MEMORIAM

CHRISSIE MACDONALD



Mrs Chrissie MacDonald, better known to us as 'Chrissie Tobson', was dearly loved, greatly respected, and much appreciated, not just in Bernera but in many places across the world.

A strong woman with an indomitable spirit, accompanied by a great sense of humour, she encouraged and helped others by her innate positivity and love of life.

Born in 1933 on the beautiful Island of Berneray, Chrissie loved her isle of birth and its rich Gaelic language and culture, returning each year to visit.

Leaving Berneray Primary School she continued to Sir E Scott secondary Tarbert, Harris, before training to become a nurse. Beginning in the Lewis Hospital before alighting to Redlands Hospital, Glasgow. It was here that the Lord led Chrissie to meet, fall in love and marry an island policeman, named Angus Alick Macdonald, in Gardener Street Church of Scotland during 1956, where both were members.

Her home in Glasgow was an oasis of hospitality, which she replicated at the family home at 17 Tobson on their return to the island in 1964. Experienced by people from all over the world, including television personalities, journalists, and food critics. Chrissie spent many years employed in the Home Care Service, before finally retiring from the Bernera Care Unit in 1996.

Ever willing to incarnate God's command to love one's neighbour as oneself, Chrissie was actively involved in many voluntary initiatives in the Community. The "meals on wheels" service in Bernera and the Western Isles Tourist Board to name but two.

Amusingly, Chrissie would often regale us at our after-service cups of tea, of how during the past week she had been on the exercise bike at the Sports Centre as part of her cardiac rehab. Before bursting our bubble of acclamation by saying, "Then we went for tea, scones and cream in the Café".

We thank God for a life well lived in the light, inspiration, and love of Jesus, and for every remembrance we have of our dear sister in Christ, Chrissie.

Her Funeral Service and Committal took place in Bosta Cemetery on 18th February 2021.

We commit Anne, Calum Angus and Malcolm and the wider family to the Lord's keeping at this sad time. 'Is beannaichte na mairbh a gheibh bàs anns an Tighearna, à seo a-mach: Seadh, tha an Spiorad ag ràdh, a-chum gum faigh iad fois on saothair; agus leanaidh an obraichean iad', Taisb 14:13

Rev Hugh Stewart

DONALD IAN MACLEOD



Donald Ian MacLeod – originally of Kirkibost, Great Bernera and later of Leurbost, Lochs – who passed away recently at his home in Faversham, Kent – was a man of many talents who achieved much in his life. His social media profile had him listed as a broadcaster and psychologist – he spent much of his life performing these roles but he was involved in much within these disciplines and a lot more besides.

He was born in Glasgow in 1948, a son of island parents. At the age of three the family moved to his maternal grandparents home in Kirkibost, Great Bernera which would, in later life, inspire him to write stories titled “Eadar Da Shaoghal” (Between Two Worlds) – broadcast, in recent years, on “BBC Radio nan Gaidheal” and published in a book by “Acair Books” in 2019, which I believe neatly bookended his life.

Although the family moved to his paternal grandparents home in Leurbost, Lochs in 1956 the family commuted constantly to Kirkibost – in maintaining the croft there till the early 1970s when the house and croft sadly went out of

the family. Donald would leave these islands in his mid teens to pursue his many activities such as playing in music bands, acquiring degrees at university, embarking on a career as a psychologist and later, of course, his multi-faceted involvement in broadcasting – both in TV and radio and in both his languages of Gaelic and English.

He became involved in working in Gaelic TV and radio programmes in Scotland – mainly on “BBC Alba” and “Radio nan Gaidheal.” One of the first of these was a TV documentary about Count Robin de la Lanne Mirrlees – the landowner of the “Bernera Estate” who had bought and come to live in our old family home at 9 Kirkibost. Donald also was the subject of TV documentaries about himself such as “Taisdeallach” (Pilgrimage)- half of which was filmed around his beloved Bernera in 2007. During much of the last thirty years he has been a regular contributor, on many subjects, to programmes on “BBC Radio nan Gaidheal” such as “Coinneach Maciomhair”, “Aithris nan Maidne” and “Feasgair”.

My brother Donald Ian MacLeod always thought of himself as a man from Bernera – he was certainly one of the most gifted of his generation. He will be deeply mourned and sadly missed by his family and so many more from near and far.

Norman Macleod

BEFRIENDING LEWIS AND HARRIS

Could you spare up to an hour a week to chat to someone on the phone or via Zoom? If so, Befriending Lewis and Harris would love to hear from you. They urgently need telephone befrienders to build warm relationships with people of all ages, especially men and young adults.

Full training and support will be given. To find out more, please get in touch on **07496 081902** or email **info@befriendinglewis.org.uk**

BERNERA BRIDGE UPDATE

Preliminary activity has commenced in preparation for construction work to start on the new Bernera Bridge crossing. Contractors are on site diverting utility services and accesses are being created to areas where geotechnical engineers will confirm rock and foundation levels. The main construction works will commence in April in advance of the bridge components starting to arrive.

Current estimates indicate that the bridge will be in place by the end of June.

POSTAL VOTING - SCOTTISH PARLIAMENT ELECTION 6TH MAY 2021

Electors in the Western Isles who plan to vote by post in the Scottish Parliament Election on Thursday 6th May 2021 are encouraged to register as soon as possible by filling in the postal application form and sending it to the Electoral Registration Officer.

Malcolm Burr, Returning Officer, said: "Everyone is entitled to vote by post. You can apply for a postal vote for one election, for a set time, or for this and all future elections. To apply for a postal vote you should contact the Electoral Registration Officer on **01851 706262** or you can download a Postal Vote Application Form. For the Scottish Parliament Election the deadline to apply for a Postal or Proxy Vote is 5pm on Tuesday 6th April 2021.

NHS WESTERN ISLES

The vaccination program continues to make excellent progress within the Western Isles. Those currently being invited to come forward for a first dose appointment are:

Anyone aged 40 or over; or Anyone in the 16-64 at risk group; or Unpaid carers aged 16 or over.

If you are included in one of the categories above, please call for an appointment on **0808 196 8383**. Alternatively email **wi.covidvax@nhs.scot** and they will contact you. The phone line is open Monday to Friday 9.30am - 5pm. Please note that NHS staff will be continuing to contact eligible individuals for appointments, but NHS Western Isles wish to ensure as many people are vaccinated as possible at available clinics over the coming weeks.

If you have been given an appointment that you are unable to attend, or would like to change your appointment, please get in touch as soon as possible so that your appointment can be offered to someone else, and so they can reduce the risk of vaccine wastage.

BERNERA BAKES... MINCED BEEF PIE

This tasty and easy beef pie recipe will quickly become a family favourite. Serve with mounds of mash and some veg.

Ingredients:

2 tbsp vegetable oil
500g beef mince
1 onion, chopped
1 tbsp tomato purée
1.5 tbsps plain flour
70g mushrooms, chopped
250ml of stout or beef stock
Dash of Worcestershire sauce
400g shortcrust pastry
1 egg yolk, lightly beaten

Method:

1. Preheat the oven to 200°C

2. Heat the oil in a deep frying pan and fry the beef mince for 4-5 mins

3. Add the onion and cook for 2-3 mins, stir in the tomato purée and cook for 2-3 more mins. Stir in the flour and cook for a further minute, then add the chopped mushrooms, the stout or beef stock and a couple of dashes of Worcestershire sauce. Bring to the boil, then reduce the heat, cover the pan and simmer for 20 mins. Set aside and leave to cool, then turn the meat mixture into a 1L pie dish

4. Roll out the pastry on a floured work surface until it is slightly larger than the pie dish. Gently drape the pastry over the dish, pressing firmly onto the edges.

Trim, then shape the edges into a fluted shape.

5. Cut some leaf shapes out of the trimmings and decorate the top of the pie sticking them to the pastry with the beaten egg yolk.

6. Make three or four slits in the pastry to allow the steam to escape then brush the pie with the rest of the beaten egg and bake in the oven for 20 to 25 mins, or until golden brown.

7. To serve slice into wedges.



Careen MacLennan
Kirkibost

BERNERA MUSEUM UPDATE



The Trustees of the Museum have taken advantage of being closed during the pandemic to undertake some work within the museum.

The walls and woodwork within the display area have been repainted, the first time since the museum was opened all those years ago, and there is now a new freshness within the room.

A new display case has been purchased for the Iron Age Artifacts which not only displays them more advantageously but is also more secure for these valuable, but priceless, items. This new case also has display drawers which will allow the presentation of smaller items within the collection to be shown, which are currently in storage.

Margaret Ferguson has also loaned the museum the three portraits she painted of Bernera Men lost on the lolaire, and these are now on show in the museum. Once the planned lolaire Exhibition has been built these portraits will be moved there.



The posting of the Photographic Archive on Facebook during 2020 has now come to an end as the full collection has been shown, it can still be found on Facebook or the Museum Website. The Trustees would like to thank everyone for their kind comments on how much they enjoyed seeing the photos and for corrections to the information shown, as well as photos added to the collection. It is felt that this project was a great success and the Trustees are proud to have been able to share with everyone.

At this time the Trustees do not know if they will be able to open the Museum and Iron Age House this year. With the requirements for ventilation, hygiene and social distancing currently in place it is felt that neither place would be safe for visitors, volunteers and the community, however if things change during the course of the year this will be reviewed.

Colin Halliday
Kirkibost



POSTCARDS FROM THE ISLANDS - STEELIN TIME



I am so excited to announce my forthcoming Blues album "Steelin Time", which will be released to most online music stores on 15th March 2021.

The album was the product of my winter lockdown and is a homage to the old school, delta and picking blues styles of the deep south. There are also some electric blues tracks and even a R&B track.

I play all the instruments, including drum and piano/organ, and sing all the vocals. I hope, very much, that you like it, and would love you to visit my website **markstylesmusic.com** to take preview of the album ahead of its release date. For those who are interested in purchasing the album, it can be downloaded from my website ahead of release elsewhere.

Mark Styles
Tobson



POSTCARDS FROM THE ISLANDS - REBECCA STYLES ART

Hello all, I hope you are well, it's Rebecca, the artist from Tobson with a little update from the studio.

Just over a year ago I set off on my career journey into the vibrant, vast, and somewhat confusing world of turning pro as an artist. As in all industries, the road to becoming a professional is like a game of chess; making the right moves in the right order, networks, finances and business; and when you have never played chess before there's a surprising amount of theoretical learning to do besides throwing your paints around.



However, when in lockdown there is also the time to dig in and get motivated, and so my skill building began two fold. I bought a year planner and diary for the first time in my life, and set about working on improving my painting skills in my studio, and I'm glad to report that last year's grind is just beginning to pay off.

In the summer I took a self penned residency around Lewis and Harris, making sketches and taking notes of places I felt inspired to study and paint. Staying in our campervan at as many locations as we could before the chilly nights took hold, I covered some ground, and by the end of the tour I felt like I had

begun to make connections to the landscape of our new home. The surprise revelation came when I was back in the studio and for the first time ever I crushed and ground a stone I had found on the beach at Mealista until it was powdered. I mixed it with refined walnut oil and discovered I had made the most glorious shade of oil paint from the landscape right here under our feet; and there in began the start of a passionate love affair with involving the earth in my art.

My discovery is of course nothing new; since before the evolution of manufactured paints all the greatest artists we know of from the renaissance period and before, were grinding their colours in the pestle and mortar ready to mix with a whole compendium of recipes in order to create the masterpieces we recognize so easily today, and let's face it, it worked out pretty well for them! And so I have become a modern day hunter gatherer of soil, rock, pebble, shale, dust, sand, and earth. With my artwork now on the verge of realising its full potential as the showcase of what the land here has to offer, I have just



received the happy news that the panel at the Visual Arts and Craft Makers Awards Scotland (known as VACMA, and sponsored by the National Lottery, Highlife, and XPO North) think I'm onto something too. I have been awarded an Emerging Artists bursary, so that this summer I can take some trips out to our offshore islands to paint, sketch, and gather my colours. Which in turn will inspire the development of the body of work I will show in my exhibition at the gallery space at Talla Na Mara, Harris, in November 2022.



Out to sea it is then, I can't wait! It will be so exciting to touch new ground and see the coast from a different perspective. Hopefully I will return with a backpack brimming with earths and a sketchbook full of ideas. Until then it will be more planning, more learning, more networking, and more painting practice. I will be sure to let you know how I get on when I return. Until then, much love and stay safe all x

www.rebeccastyles.co.uk
facebook- @rebeccastyles.co.uk
instagram - @rebeccastylesart

Rebecca Styles
Tobson



MEÓRACHADH



Tro "Lockdown" chórd e rium a bhith a' coimhead air na seann dealbhan a chuir Commun Eachdraidh Bheárnaraigh air an eadar-líon.

Nuair a chunnaic mi na daoine bha mi a' smaoineachadh díreach dé cho cruaidh sa bha beatha aig an ám sin: Obair air an lot, a' treabhadh is a' cuir buntáta, a' dupadh agus a' rúsgadh nan caorach, a' buain na mónach neo a'dol a-mach ag iasgach.

Nuair a bha mi a'fás suas ann an Siorramachd Dhún Phris, bha sinn a' fuireach air tuathanas mór oir bha m'athair ag obair an sin. Bha iad a'cleachdadh innealan úr-nodha ach leis na caoraich chaidh acfhuinn tradiseanta a chleachdadh fhathast. Anns na trí ficheadan bha cothrom agam air siubhal dhan Ostair agus rinn sinn turas gu baile beag, far an robh na croitearan a'treabhadh le cuing daimh - Bha sin iongantach!

Ach tha na cúisean air atharrachadh an lá an-diugh.

Linne Macleod
Dun Innes



FOOLISHNESS OR FAITH

As we begin the process of moving out of Lockdown, we are once again thankful to those whose efforts have been expended to enable this to happen. Not least the NHS Vaccination Teams of our local Health Board, supported by the many volunteers from across our islands.

The vaccines provide us with a confidence that if we are exposed to the Covid 19 virus its impact upon us should be greatly reduced. Not that in any sense we should withdraw from taking every precaution possible, and follow all the guidance given to help keep ourselves and our neighbours safe.

Strangely, illogically, and perversely, we do not always follow the guidance provided for our own health and wellbeing. Recently I listened to a radio news interview that was being broadcast from London where a young Londoner gave his personal views on the Covid 19 virus, especially the Brazilian and South African variants. Unbelievably, instead of expressing his concern, he bombarded the listeners with a nonsensical, unstoppable, illogical, and foolish nationalistic diatribe. "I don't want any of that foreign muck. Give me good old British Covid any day!" he declared, before zealously setting out from the studio on a mission to contract Covid 19 as soon as possible.

Foolish? Yes! Responsible? No! Yet such people and worldviews exist. Blinded by an illogical zeal he not only placed himself in harm's way, but also others. Notwithstanding how offensive and ill-considered he was being to all the NHS and care staff, who would be required to deal with the consequences of his self-centred, egotistical, and selfish behaviour.

In considering this man's behaviour we may shake our heads in astonishment. But, if we are to be honest, as followers of Jesus, we too were equally as foolish and illogical before we came to faith in Jesus. Perhaps not in our speech, but most certainly in our hearts and wills. Unwilling to turn away from sin and receive Jesus by faith into our hearts, we chose instead to live lives independent of God's love and grace. Yet God's love, unlike all the Covid Vaccines, not only fights against sin, in and through faith in Jesus, it overcomes forever.

At this special time of year Jesus Himself reminds us of His victory over sin, death and the grave, and how by grace we are totally protected from its eternal and deadly consequences.

Clearly and concisely expressed by Himself at His friend, Lazarus' graveside:

"I am the resurrection and the life. He who believes in Me, though he may die, he shall live. And whoever lives and believes in Me shall never die. Do you believe this?", **John 11: 25 -26**

Rev Hugh Maurice Stewart
Uig & Bernera

